

1951

“IT HAD TO BE.”

Julius Rosenberg, convicted spy, on his death sentence, 1951

EGYPT RENOUNCED ITS 1936 TREATY THAT GRANTED BRITAIN a lease on the Suez base, in October. Britain refused to withdraw and a guerilla war began in the **Suez Canal Zone**.

In March, the Iranian government nationalized its oil industry, which had been dominated by the **Anglo-Iranian Oil Company**. Britain responded with a **worldwide embargo** on Iranian oil.

A new era dawned in **nuclear power** when the first nuclear power plant, in Idaho, produced around 100 kW of power—enough for four 100 watt light bulbs.

Fears about the **spread of communism** deepened as **Julius and Ethel Rosenberg** were accused of stealing information from the US for the Soviets. British Foreign Office officials **Guy Burgess** and **Donald Maclean** disappeared on 28 May—it was later found out that they had **defected** to the Soviet Union.



The Rosenbergs awaiting trial. Americans Julius and Ethel Rosenberg were found guilty of smuggling atomic secrets to the Soviet Union.

1952



Thousands of suspected Mau Mau activists in Kenya were arrested following open revolt against British rule.

INDOCHINA PROVED VOLATILE THROUGHOUT THE YEAR. In April, the French launched a big push to smash the **Viet Minh resistance** northwest of Saigon. In October, another French operation targeted Viet Minh supply bases.

A **peace treaty** that Japan had signed in San Francisco, US, in 1951 went into effect on April 28, making the country an **independent state** again.

On May 27, **East Germany** closed its border with **West Germany**. A 30-ft (10-m) wide **“control strip”** was dug along the border.

King George VI of Britain died on February 6. His daughter, **Elizabeth**, was officially proclaimed queen two days later.

Opposition to British rule led to the **Mau Mau Rebellion in Kenya**. The Mau Mau were an anticolonial insurgent army. They began raiding white-settler farms, and by the end of the year the British had declared a state of emergency.

The **European Coal and Steel Community** came into being in July. Comprised of six nations, it created a **“common market”** for coal and steel, and laid down the



EVA PERON (1919–52)

Maria Eva Duarte de Perón, or “Evita,” played a crucial role in helping her husband, Juan Perón, become Argentinean president. She was idolized by the poor, and began many programs of social welfare and reform. She died of cancer at age 32.

foundations for the future European Union.

A **military coup in Egypt** headed by Colonel Gamal Abdal Nasser’s **Committee of Free Officers** seized control of the government in July. Egypt became a republic in 1953.

The first atomic bombs had been dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945. The much more powerful **hydrogen bomb**, or H-bomb, was tested by the US on November 1.

The world’s first successful use of a **mechanical heart** was announced in the US, on July 3. The **Dodrill-GMR** machine kept blood circulating for 50 minutes during open-heart surgery.

1953



STALIN’S POLICIES WERE BECOMING INCREASINGLY ANTI-SEMITIC. At the end of 1952, he told his Politburo that all Jews were sympathetic to America. On January 13, nine doctors were arrested for conspiring to murder prominent figures in the Soviet armed forces. Six of them were Jews. These accusations were

Hillary and Norgay
Edmund Hillary and Sherpa Tenzing Norgay become the first to successfully reach the summit of Mount Everest, the highest point on Earth, during the British Everest Expedition of 1953.

met by reactions of foreboding in Western Europe. The doctors were freed after **Stalin died** of a stroke in March.

Stalin’s death led to a major **power struggle** in the Kremlin where a moderate coalition, headed by **Georgi Malenkov** (1902–88), took over. His moderate policies became unpopular and **Lavrenty Beria** (1899–1953), who had been the head of Stalin’s secret police, tried to gain power.

Beria was **charged with treason** and was then shot in the back of a truck, in what seems to have been a summary **assassination**.



50 THOUSAND

THE NUMBER OF
AFRICANS WHO DIED IN THE MAU MAU UPRISING

March 8 Iran votes to nationalize its oil industry

May 14 Colored people lose right to vote in South Africa

May 28 British spies Guy Burgess and Donald MacLean go missing

December 24 Libya proclaims its independence

July 26 Death of Eva Perón (b. 1919)

July 26 King Farouk of Egypt abdicates

September 2 Japan formally surrenders to the Allies, ending War in the Pacific

October 3 Britain tests its first atomic weapon

November 1 First hydrogen bomb tested in Pacific by US

November 3 Dwight D. Eisenhower voted in as US President

January 1 China’s first five year plan, an economic development initiative, begins

January 3 Samuel Beckett’s play *Waiting For Godot* premieres in Paris

January 14 Josip Tito elected Yugoslav president

March 5 King Norodom Sihanouk proclaims independence for Cambodia

March 5 Death of Joseph Stalin (Russian leader (b. 1879))

April 8 Jomo Kenyatta, Mau Mau leader, arrested and jailed

April 25 James D. Watson and Francis Crick discover DNA

May 29 Everest conquered by Edmund Hillary and Tenzing Norgay